

EU4Health is a funding program initiated by the European Union (EU) to strengthen healthcare systems across Europe and improve the overall health and well-being of EU citizens. Launched in 2021 as a response to the COVID-19 pandemic, the program is part of the EU's long-term budget for 2021–2027, with an allocation of €5.1 billion. It is the largest health program ever financed by the EU and focuses on enhancing healthcare resilience, preparedness, and access to healthcare services.

Background

The EU4Health program was created in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, which highlighted the need for a more robust healthcare infrastructure across the EU. The program aims to mitigate the healthcare disparities that emerged during the pandemic, especially in preparedness and response capabilities, and to ensure that EU countries can effectively manage future health crises.

Objectives

EU4Health has four primary objectives:

Crisis Preparedness and Management: Strengthen the capacity of EU countries to prevent, prepare for, and respond to serious cross-border health threats. This includes developing medical stockpiles, enhancing early warning systems, and supporting response capacities at national and EU levels.

Access to Medicines and Innovation: Ensure that EU citizens have access to affordable medicines, vaccines, and medical equipment. The program aims to reduce dependence on external supply chains and to promote the development and availability of innovative health products and technologies.

Strengthening Health Systems and Workforce: Support national healthcare systems by

improving the resilience, capacity, and efficiency of healthcare services. This includes training healthcare professionals, fostering cross-border cooperation, and enhancing digital health infrastructure.

Prevention and Health Promotion: Encourage EU citizens to adopt healthier lifestyles by supporting initiatives on disease prevention, health promotion, and public health information campaigns. Key areas of focus include cancer, mental health, and communicable and non-communicable diseases.

Key actions and initiatives

EU4Health funds a wide range of activities designed to achieve its objectives. Key initiatives include:

Health Crisis Preparedness: Support for the European Health Emergency Preparedness and Response Authority (HERA), aimed at coordinating responses to health emergencies across the EU.

Digital Health Transformation: Investment in digital health infrastructure and the development of the European Health Data Space to facilitate secure data sharing and interoperability between healthcare systems.

Cancer Prevention and Care: Funding initiatives in line with Europe's Beating Cancer Plan, targeting early detection, diagnosis, treatment, and survivorship care.

Mental Health Support: Programs addressing the mental health impact of the pandemic, including initiatives for youth mental health, mental health in the workplace, and suicide prevention.

Healthcare Workforce Development: Grants and training opportunities for healthcare professionals to address skill shortages and support cross-border collaboration.

Funding and implementation

EU4Health has an allocated budget of €5.1 billion for the 2021-2027 period. Funds are distributed through grants, tenders, and other financing mechanisms managed by the European Health and Digital Executive Agency (HaDEA). Member states, health organizations, and non-governmental organizations can apply for EU4Health funding to implement health-related projects and initiatives in line with the program's objectives.

Governance and oversight

The program is overseen by the European Commission, in collaboration with the European Parliament and the Council of the European Union. EU4Health works closely with national health authorities, the European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control (ECDC), and the European Medicines Agency (EMA) to align its initiatives with existing EU health policies.

Impact and future perspectives

EU4Health is expected to play a pivotal role in shaping a more integrated and resilient healthcare system in Europe. By addressing weaknesses exposed by the pandemic, the program aims to reduce health inequalities, enhance healthcare accessibility, and promote innovation in health services. The program also supports the EU's goals in digital health and the use of data to improve health outcomes.

See also

European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control (ECDC)

European Medicines Agency (EMA)

References

"EU4Health programme 2021-2027 – a vision for a healthier European Union - European Commission". health.ec.europa.eu. 2024-09-20. Retrieved 2024-11-25.

"European Parliament". European Parliament. Retrieved 2024-11-25.